

HTML Essentials

Headings · Paragraphs · Lists · Description Lists

Complete Reference with Examples

This guide covers the fundamental HTML elements used to structure web content — headings for titles and sections, paragraphs for readable text, ordered and unordered lists for grouped items, and description lists for term-definition pairs.

1. HTML Headings

HTML provides **six levels of headings**, from `<h1>` (most important) to `<h6>` (least important). Headings help structure a page hierarchically and are critical for SEO and accessibility.

Heading Tags at a Glance

Tag	Default Size	Typical Use
<code><h1></code>	32px	Page Title / Main Heading
<code><h2></code>	24px	Section Heading
<code><h3></code>	20px	Sub-Section Heading
<code><h4></code>	16px	Sub-Sub Heading
<code><h5></code>	13px	Minor Heading
<code><h6></code>	11px	Smallest Heading

Syntax

```
<h1>This is a Heading 1</h1>
```

```
<h2>This is a Heading 2</h2>

<h3>This is a Heading 3</h3>

<h4>This is a Heading 4</h4>

<h5>This is a Heading 5</h5>

<h6>This is a Heading 6</h6>
```

Visual Output

Heading 1 — Page Title

Heading 2 — Section Title

Heading 3 — Sub-Section

Heading 4 — Sub-Sub-Section

Heading 5 — Minor Heading

Heading 6 — Smallest Heading

Best Practice: Use only one `<h1>` per page (for the main title). Do not skip heading levels (e.g., jump from `<h2>` to `<h4>`). Headings should reflect the document outline, not be used for styling.

2. HTML Paragraphs

The `<p>` tag defines a paragraph. Browsers automatically add space (margin) before and after paragraphs. Paragraphs are block-level elements.

Basic Paragraph Example

```
<p>This is the first paragraph. It contains some text.</p>

<p>This is the second paragraph. Browsers add
  spacing between paragraphs automatically.</p>

<p>HTML ignores extra   spaces and
  line
  breaks inside paragraph tags.</p>
```

This is the first paragraph. It contains some text.

This is the second paragraph. Browsers add spacing between paragraphs automatically.

HTML ignores extra spaces and line breaks inside paragraph tags.

Related Text Elements

Tag	Name	Description
<code>
</code>	Line Break	Inserts a single line break without starting a new paragraph
<code><hr></code>	Horizontal Rule	Creates a thematic break / horizontal line
<code><pre></code>	Preformatted	Preserves whitespace and line breaks exactly
<code><blockquote></code>	Block Quote	Indented block for long quotations

Using `<br>` and `<hr>` with Paragraphs

```
<p>Line one.<br>
Line two on a new line.</p>

<hr>

<p>This paragraph appears after the horizontal rule.</p>
```

Line one.

Line two on a new line.



This paragraph appears after the horizontal rule.

3. HTML Lists

HTML supports three types of lists: **Unordered** (bulleted), **Ordered** (numbered), and **Nested** (lists within lists). Each list item is defined using the `<li>` tag.

3a. Unordered List `<ul>`

An unordered list displays items with bullet points. The **type** attribute (or CSS *list-style-type*) controls bullet style.

```
<ul>
  <li>Apples</li>
  <li>Bananas</li>
  <li>Cherries</li>
</ul>
```

- Apples
- Bananas

- Cherries

Bullet Style Options (CSS list-style-type)

Value	Symbol	Description
disc	●	Filled circle (default)
circle	■	Hollow circle
square	■	Filled square
none		No bullet marker

3b. Ordered List

An ordered list numbers items automatically. The **type** attribute sets the numbering style; **start** sets the beginning number.

```
<ol type='1' start='1'>
  <li>First Step</li>
  <li>Second Step</li>
  <li>Third Step</li>
</ol>
```

1. First Step
2. Second Step
3. Third Step

Ordered List type Attribute Values

type Value	Example	Description
1	1, 2, 3 ...	Decimal numbers (default)
A	A, B, C ...	Uppercase letters
a	a, b, c ...	Lowercase letters
I	I, II, III ...	Uppercase Roman numerals
i	i, ii, iii ...	Lowercase Roman numerals

3c. Nested Lists

Lists can be nested inside each other. Any or can be placed inside an element to create a sub-list.

```

<ul>
  <li>Fruits
    <ul>
      <li>Mango</li>
      <li>Papaya</li>
    </ul>
  </li>
  <li>Vegetables
    <ol>
      <li>Carrot</li>
      <li>Spinach</li>
    </ol>
  </li>
</ul>

```

- Fruits
 - Mango
 - Papaya
- Vegetables
 1. Carrot
 2. Spinach

4. Description Lists <dl>

A **Description List** is used to display term-definition pairs, like a glossary or dictionary. It uses three tags together:

Tag	Name	Role
<dl>	Description List	The container element for the entire list
<dt>	Description Term	Defines the term being described
<dd>	Description Detail	Provides the definition or description of the term

Basic Description List Example

```

<dl>
  <dt>HTML</dt>

```

```

<dd>HyperText Markup Language – the standard language
    for creating web pages.</dd>

<dt>CSS</dt>

<dd>Cascading Style Sheets – used to style HTML elements.</dd>

<dt>JavaScript</dt>

<dd>A scripting language for making web pages interactive.</dd>
</dl>

```

HTML

HyperText Markup Language — the standard language for creating web pages.

CSS

Cascading Style Sheets — used to style HTML elements.

JavaScript

A scripting language for making web pages interactive.

Multiple Definitions per Term

A single `<dt>` can have multiple `<dd>` elements, and multiple `<dt>` elements can share one `<dd>`.

```

<dl>

  <dt>Python</dt>

  <dt>py</dt>          <!-- two terms, one definition -->

  <dd>A high-level, general-purpose programming language.</dd>

  <dt>Compiler</dt>

  <dd>Translates entire source code to machine code at once.</dd>

  <dd>Examples: GCC, Clang, javac.</dd> <!-- two definitions -->

</dl>

```

5. Complete HTML Page Example

The following example shows all four concepts — headings, paragraphs, lists, and a description list — used together in a single HTML document.

```

<!DOCTYPE html>

<html lang='en'>

<head>

  <meta charset='UTF-8'>

```

```

<title>Web Technologies Guide</title>

</head>

<body>

  <h1>Web Technologies Guide</h1>

  <p>Welcome! This guide introduces core web technologies.</p>

  <h2>Front-End Technologies</h2>

  <p>Front-end refers to everything the user sees in a browser.</p>

  <h3>Core Languages (Ordered List)</h3>

  <ol>

    <li>HTML – Structure</li>

    <li>CSS – Styling</li>

    <li>JavaScript – Interactivity</li>

  </ol>

  <h3>Popular Frameworks (Unordered List)</h3>

  <ul>

    <li>React</li>

    <li>Vue.js</li>

    <li>Angular</li>

  </ul>

  <h2>Key Terms (Description List)</h2>

  <dl>

    <dt>DOM</dt>

    <dd>Document Object Model – tree structure of an HTML page.</dd>

    <dt>API</dt>

    <dd>Application Programming Interface.</dd>

  </dl>

</body>

</html>

```

6. Quick Reference Card

Element	Tag(s)	Key Attributes	Notes
---------	--------	----------------	-------

Headings	<h1>-<h6>	id, class, style	h1=most, h6=least important
Paragraph	<p>	id, class, style, align	Block-level; auto margin
Line Break	 	—	Void element; no closing tag
Horiz. Rule	<hr>	size, color, width	Thematic break
Unordered List	+	type (disc circle square)	Bullet points
Ordered List	+	type, start, reversed	Numbered items
Description List	<dl><dt><dd>	—	Term + definition pairs

This document covers all fundamental HTML structuring elements. Practice by building simple web pages and experiment with each element's attributes.